

Neelam Chhiber

Neelam Chhiber (born 1960s) is the Co-Founder and Managing Trustee of Industree Foundation, and an industrial designer by training from the National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad. Over three decades, she has worked at the intersection of design, enterprise, gender, and climate to economically empower India's 200-million-strong artisan workforce — predominantly women — by connecting them to mainstream national and global supply chains with dignity.

Education

- Industrial Design, National Institute of Design (NID), Ahmedabad.

Career

Began career applying design to the artisan and craft sector, observing the deep disconnect between industrial design's potential and its reach into rural communities. Co-founded Industree Foundation in 2000 to address structural barriers — informality, low wages, lack of market access — keeping India's artisan workforce locked out of mainstream value chains.

Over two decades as Managing Trustee, built self-sustaining women-owned producer collectives supplying IKEA, H&M Home, and the Future Group. Developed the proprietary 6C Framework for collective enterprise formation. Launched Flourish — a 100% producer-owned e-commerce platform. Pioneered Mission Creative Million to strengthen livelihoods for a million producers. Gradually transitioned leadership to CEO Neju George Abraham from 2019; formal handover October 2023. Serves as Independent Director at Caratlane and previously at Prestige Group. Board Member, Catalyst 2030 and Creative Million.

Neelam's Story

Trained as an industrial designer at NID Ahmedabad, Neelam entered the artisan sector and found design deeply elitist — its benefits reaching urban consumers while the rural women who made the products earned subsistence wages with no security, no ownership, no voice. In 2000, she co-founded Industree Foundation with a single conviction: that economic empowerment — regular income, social security, and enterprise ownership — is the only sustainable pathway to women's social empowerment. Working directly in four states over two decades, Neelam and her team built self-sustaining women-led collectives that today supply IKEA and H&M Home, earn living wages, hold social security, and continue to thrive independently after Industree's exit — proof that the model works.



Leadership at Industree

Neelam pioneered the 6C Framework — Collective, Capacity, Commerce, Capital, Compliance, and Community — as a structured, replicable approach to forming women-owned producer enterprises in rural and peri-urban India. Under her leadership, Industree directly impacted 200,000+ artisan producers across four states, moved them from informal daily labour into formal employment with social security, and connected them to global supply chains. Her blended capital model uses philanthropic capital to capacity-build producers until collectives become commercially self-sustaining — at which point Industree exits and the collective continues independently.

Producer collectives under Ekta (apparel, embroidery, textiles) and GreenKraft (sustainable home products) supply IKEA, H&M Home, and Future Group. Flourish, a 100% producer-owned e-commerce site, enables direct-to-consumer sales globally.

Talks and Articles

JEDi Talk: Exclusively Inclusive

Neelam discusses co-creating collaboratives for artisan inclusion and scaling social impact at Industree Foundation.

https://youtu.be/mE_Ox8X37O8?si=kf47M81cMsTncyxG

IDR Profile and Contributions

Neelam Chhiber's IDR page details her role building ecosystems for artisan ownership and market links

<https://idronline.org/contributor/neelam-chhiber/>

<https://youtu.be/oVKFQyEJ2z0?si=EOTGDtXRdUbVPIK>

<https://youtu.be/kmmcsfIdPl?si=DoAYeiKm5tJraYIH>